Arthritis

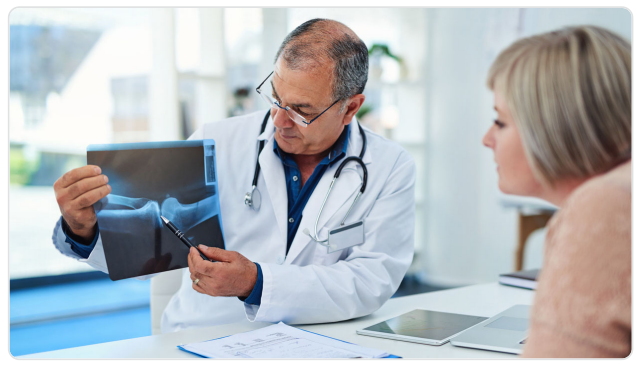
Arthritis Basics

MARCH 22, 2024

For Everyone

KEY POINTS

- Arthritis affects about 1 in 5 U.S. adults.
- It affects the joints, tissues around the joint, and other connective tissues.
- Arthritis is a leading cause of work disability among adults.
- People with other chronic conditions—such as obesity, diabetes, and heart disease—often have arthritis.



Overview

Arthritis is a general term for conditions that affect the joints, tissues around joints, and other connective tissues. There are more than 100 types of arthritis.

The causes of some forms of arthritis are unknown.

Did you know?

About 54 million U.S. adults have arthritis.[1] The number of people with arthritis is expected to increase as the population grows and ages.[2]

Risk factors

Some behaviors and characteristics can increase your chances of developing arthritis.

Several of these risk factors are within your control, including:

- Smoking.
- Having overweight or obesity.
- Joint injuries—like from sports, falls, and accidents.
- Work-related activities that lead to joint injury—like bending, squatting, and other repetitive motions.

Learn more about risk factors and what you can do lower your risk of developing arthritis.

Symptoms and diagnosis

Symptoms vary by arthritis type but usually include joint pain and stiffness.

Health care providers can diagnose arthritis by:

- Reviewing your health and family history.
- Doing a physical exam.

- Taking X-rays.
- Doing lab tests (as needed).

Once you know the type of arthritis you have, you can work with your provider to decide on the best ways to manage and treat it.

Managing your arthritis

It is important to manage symptoms

Managing arthritis symptoms helps you:

- Prevent or delay it from getting worse or causing disability.
- Reduce pain.
- Improve your overall health and well-being.

Ways to manage arthritis

Five ways to manage arthritis and its symptoms:

- Learn self-management skills.
- Be physically active.
- Manage your weight.
- Protect your joints.
- Talk to your health care provider if you have symptoms.
    - The earlier you receive an arthritis diagnosis, the sooner you can begin treatment to lessen its effects and prevent or delay it from getting worse.



Joint-friendly physical activity—like walking—can help arthritis pain.

Treatment

Treatment options

There is no cure for arthritis, but it can be treated and managed.

Treatments vary depending on arthritis type. They may include:

- Over-the-counter medicines.
- Physical therapy.
- Prescription medicines.
- Surgery, if needed.

Your provider will talk to you about these and other treatment options that are right for your arthritis type and personal needs.

Expert Care

Rheumatologists are doctors who are trained as experts in diagnosing, treating, and caring for people with arthritis.

Find a rheumatologist near you

For personalized recommendations, call the Arthritis Foundation helpline at 1-800-283-7800.

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

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REFERENCES

1. National Center for Health Statistics. National Health Interview Survey Data, 2021–2023. Accessed August 6, 2024. https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/nhis/data-questionnaires-documentation.htm
2. Hootman JM, Helmick CG, Barbour KE, Theis KA, Boring MA. Updated projected prevalence of self-reported doctor-diagnosed arthritis and arthritis attributable activity limitation among US adults, 2015–2040. *Arthritis Rheumatol.* 2016;68(7):1582–1587. doi:10.1002/art.39692